

FRONTIER

A combination and betting game of nerve, alliances, and the last dollar



DECKS	CARDS EXCLUDED	PLAYERS	DURATION	COMPLEXITY
1×	None	2–6	20–30 min	Medium

1 Objective

Five rounds. Each round, build the strongest hand from your own cards and the shared Table Cards, and bet on it. Leave the table with more money than you brought.

2 The Cards

50 cards in five **Symbols** of ten: **1–9** and the **Cypher Ø**, worth 10. The Symbols belong to three **Colors**:

Red	♥ Hearts ♦ Diamonds
Blue	♠ Spades ♣ Clubs
Black	★ Stars

The Circle. In a Run, Ø links 9 and 1: 8♣ 9♦ Ø♥ 1♠ is a Run. Ø still counts 10, and 1 counts 1.

3 Setup

All money is counted in **units** — the smallest piece on the table: a chip, a coin, a \$5 note. Each player brings a stake of **at least 10 units**, in whole units. For an even game, everyone brings the same stake; stakes may also differ. The minimum bet is 1 unit. Shuffle the deck and choose the dealer at random.

4 A Round

Six cards are always in reach: your own, plus the face-up Table Cards everyone shares.

Round	1	2	3	4	5
Your cards	1	2	3	4	5
Table Cards	5	4	3	2	1

Deal. The dealer lays out the Table Cards, then deals every player up to the round's hand size. Keep your cards hidden until the showdown.

Betting. The player left of the dealer opens, then play goes clockwise:

- **Open** — the first player bets at least 1 unit.
- **Call** — match the highest bet.
- **Raise** — match the highest bet and add at least 1 unit.
- **Fold** — leave the round. If you haven't bet yet, pay 1 unit first.

Betting continues until everyone still in has put in the same amount. **Limit:** no one's bet may exceed what the poorest player at the table held when the round began.

Showdown. Reveal the own cards you play — if any — and name the Table Cards you add. The strongest hand (Section 5) takes the pot. A tie splits it; an odd unit goes to the tied player nearest the dealer's left.

Refill. Played cards and Table Cards go to the discard pile; unplayed cards stay in your hand. Then, clockwise from the dealer's left, each player may discard any number of hand cards **face up**. Shuffle the discard pile into the deck. Anyone left with nothing is out for the rest of the game — the Limit now follows the poorest player still at the table. The deal passes one seat clockwise.

5 Hand Strength

Your **hand** is the cards you play: any of your own plus any Table Cards — Table Cards alone are allowed. A Table Card serves every player at once.

What is a Combination?

Two or more cards that share a trait. A hand holds **one** combination or none — a card that doesn't fit breaks it, so play only what fits and keep the rest.

Combination	Shared trait	Example
Symbol Run	consecutive values, one Symbol	4♥ 5♥ 6♥
Same Value	equal value	7♥ 7♠ 7★
Same Symbol	one Symbol	2♥ 5♥ 9♥
Run	consecutive values	9♣ 0♦ 1♥

Which hand wins?

Compare top-down; the first difference decides.

- Size** Combination with more cards > Combination with fewer cards > No Combination.
- Type** Symbol Run > Same Value > Same Symbol > Run.
- Color** One Color > One Color + Black > Red + Blue.
- Total** Higher sum of values wins (0 = 10). Still equal: split the pot.

One Color = all Red, all Blue, or all Black. Without a combination, size and type don't count: go straight to Color. A single card counts only its value.

Examples

2♥ 5♥ 9♥	beats	7♠ 7♦	3 cards beat 2.
4♥ 5♥ 6♥	beats	2♥ 5♥ 9♥	Same size: Symbol Run beats Same Symbol.
7♥ 7♠	beats	2♥ 5♥	Same size: Same Value beats Same Symbol.
4♥ 5♦ 6♥	beats	4♠ 5★ 6♠	Equal Runs: One Color beats One Color + Black.
8♣ 9♦ 0♥	beats	9♣ 0♦ 1♥	Equal Runs, both Red + Blue: 27 beats 20.

6 End of the Game

After round 5, everyone holding more than their stake has won the difference. The biggest gain takes the table.

***The Freedom of Cards.** American Playing Cards was introduced by Simon Allmer on the USA's 250th Independence Day. Frontier is one of many games built for this 5-suit system. Learn more at simonallmer.com/americanplayingcards.*